

DEPARTMENT OF VETERANS AFFAIRS



Congressionally Mandated Report: Study of All-Cause Mortality, Including by Suicide, of Veterans

January 2026

Report Language

Section 204 of P.L. 116-171, Subsection (a),

- 1) **IN GENERAL.**—The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall seek to enter into an agreement with the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine under which the Secretary shall collaborate and coordinate with the National Academies on a revised study design to fulfill the goals of the 2019 study design of the National Academies described in the explanatory statement accompanying the Further Consolidated Appropriations Act, 2020 (P.L. 116–94), as part of current and additional research priorities of the Department of Veterans Affairs, to evaluate the effects of opioids and benzodiazepine on all-cause mortality of Veterans, including suicide, regardless of whether information relating to such deaths has been reported by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.
- 2) **GOALS.** —In carrying out the collaboration and coordination under paragraph (1), the Secretary shall seek as much as possible to achieve the same advancement of useful knowledge as the 2019 study design described in such paragraph.

Section 204 of P.L. 116-171, Subsection (d)(1),

BRIEFINGS. —The Secretary of Veterans Affairs shall brief the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives containing the interim results (1) with respect to the study under subsection (a)(1), not later than 24 months after entering into the agreement under such subsection.

Section 204 of P.L. 116-171, Subsection (e)(1)

(e) **REPORTS.** — (1) **REPORT ON STUDY.** —Not later than 90 days after the completion by the Secretary of Veterans Affairs in coordination with the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine of the study required under subsection (a)(1), the Secretary shall (A) submit to the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the Senate and the Committee on Veterans' Affairs of the House of Representatives a report on the results of the study; and (B) make such report publicly available.

Report Citation P.L. 116-171 § 204(a)(1 – 2); (d); e(1)

Background

The U.S. Congress has expressed concerns particularly about mortality, including death by suicide, among Veterans who have been prescribed opioids and benzodiazepines. Veterans are more likely than non-Veterans to experience pain, trauma, and mental health conditions from training and combat-related service and to be prescribed pharmacotherapies for treatment. Congress mandated that the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) enter into a contract with National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (NASEM), and request an ad hoc committee of NASEM be assembled to evaluate the effects of

prescribed opioid and benzodiazepine pharmacotherapies on all-cause mortality of U.S. Veterans, including suicide, focusing on practices between 2007 and 2019.

Discussion

To fulfill the requirements of P.L. 116-171 § 204(a)(1 – 2); (d); e(1), the Office of Research and Development (ORD), within Discovery, Education, and Affiliate Networks at the Veterans Health Administration (VHA), entered into a contract with NASEM from September 24, 2022, to March 31, 2025 (contract #36C24E22C0030). NASEM established a committee to independently evaluate the effects of prescribed opioid and benzodiazepine pharmacotherapies on all-cause mortality of U.S. Veterans, including suicide, focusing on practices between 2007 and 2019. The committee applied causal inference methodology and leveraged large VA and VHA datasets (such as, health care, clinical, and administrative data), Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services data, and the National Death Index to conduct its work.

On September 23, 2024, NASEM's independent Committee on Evaluating the Effects of Opioids and Benzodiazepines on All-Cause Mortality in Veterans, ORD, and the Office of Mental Health at VHA held a briefing with staff from the House and Senate Committees on Veterans' Affairs on the interim results of the study on. NASEM completed the independent study and made the report publicly available on February 6, 2025. The link to the report can be found at <https://nap.nationalacademies.org/catalog/28584/veterans-prescription-opioids-and-benzodiazepines-and-mortality-2007-2019-three>.

Conclusion

The study findings are consistent with concerns regarding the risks associated with initiation of opioid pharmacotherapy and co-prescribing benzodiazepine pharmacotherapy.

Department of Veterans Affairs
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